ubiquitous instrument in the service of China's negotiators. It was initially established to enable the Chinese Communist Party to maintain contact with 'fraternal' socialist parties. It has since evolved into the primary party organ for the cultivation of all foreign political parties and politicians. According to public reports, it now has contacts with hundreds of political parties worldwide. As Chinese expert David Shambaugh says, no ruling party or government in the world mounts anywhere near as extensive an effort to maintain links with foreign political parties and personages as the ILD. [19]

The ILD, which is the acronym by which it is commonly known, has widespread contacts within the Indian political system. The ILD has three primary functions: first, to study and report on the internal political developments, which includes serving as a 'scout' by identifying key rising stars with potential for future leadership; second, to maintain links with political personalities whom the Chinese already know or who have visited China; and, third, to expose provincial level Chinese leaders to India. At times, it also acts as a separate conduit for information between China and other countries, but a closer look reveals that several foreign ministry personnel serve in the ILD and vice versa because there is no distinction between Party and State. Research by two scholars, Christine Hackenesch and Julia Bader, establishes how the party channel is more flexible, reaches a large number of foreign political elites, and allows for engagement with influential actors outside the realm of foreign affairs diplomacy like power-brokers or families of political leaders. [20]

Given the ILD's ability to organize 'access' to the higher leadership for the foreign political personality or party delegation, it is able to persuade political figures and parties from India to visit China, by arranging high-level meetings, medical consultations, admission to educational facilities and